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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

LIN 101: Introduction to Linguistics - Sound, Structure and Meaning

Analyse language systematically instead of judging it

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Linguistics | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Linguistics is descriptive, not prescriptive. This pack introduces phonetics and phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics and sociolinguistics, using Nigerian languages and Nigerian English as data - so the examples are close to what you actually hear.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Transcribe simple words using IPA.
- Identify morphemes and word-formation processes.
- Draw a basic syntactic tree.
- Explain the difference between descriptive and prescriptive approaches.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Phonetics and phonology

Sounds first, then the systems they form.

- Articulation: place and manner of consonants, voicing.
- Vowels described by height, backness and rounding.
- IPA symbols for sounds that English spelling hides.
- Phoneme versus allophone: contrast versus variation.
- Syllable structure, stress and tone.
- Nigerian languages contribute sounds English lacks; use them as data.

Morphology and syntax

Structure at word level and sentence level.

- Morpheme: free and bound; root, stem and affix.
- Word formation: derivation, compounding, borrowing, reduplication, clipping.
- Word classes identified by distribution, not only meaning.
- Constituents and phrase structure.
- Basic tree diagrams for simple sentences.
- Grammaticality is judged against a grammar, not against taste.

> **Describe, do not scold**
> 'Ain't' and Nigerian English forms are data about rules in use. Prescriptivism belongs to style guidance, not linguistic analysis.

Semantics and sociolinguistics

Meaning and social life are part of language structure.

- Sense, reference and ambiguity.
- Synonymy, antonymy, hyponymy and entailment.
- Pragmatics: implicature and speech acts.
- Variation by region, class, gender and context.
- Code-switching and multilingual repertoires.
- Language contact, pidginisation and creolisation.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish a phoneme from an allophone.

Answer: A phoneme contrasts meaning in a language; an allophone is a variant pronunciation of the same phoneme in a context.

2. What is a bound morpheme?

Answer: A morpheme that cannot stand alone and must attach to another form, such as a plural or tense marker.

3. Why is prescriptivism not linguistic analysis?

Answer: It evaluates usage against a preferred standard rather than describing the rules speakers actually follow.

4. Give an example of code-switching.

Answer: Alternating between Igbo and English within a conversation or sentence according to topic, interlocutor or setting.

5. What does a constituency test show?

Answer: Which groups of words behave as a single structural unit in a sentence.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Learn the IPA symbols used in your course.
- [ ] Transcribe twenty words from two languages.
- [ ] Segment ten words into morphemes.
- [ ] Draw five simple tree diagrams.
- [ ] Collect three examples of code-switching you observe.
- [ ] Read one paper on Nigerian English.
- [ ] Write a short descriptive analysis with data, not opinion.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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